

Standard Myanglish System

based on currently using Myanglish

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1. Introduction

I got the idea to create this system during June-August 2020, which is during my internship at a Japanese company. We had to learn Japanese as we had to communicate with our Japanese supervisors. As a part of communication, we sent messages in Japanese. At that time, I noticed that we can type using English words to generate Japanese words such as Hiragana, Katakana and even Kanji. However, our language only has our native Myanmar words. Therefore, if we want to type in Burmese on our computer, we need to memorize the whole keyboard keys for Myanmar or else, we will have to stick the Myanmar keyboard stickers which is uncomfortable for many people. That was where I started to think of creating a keyboard which we use English words to type and then generate Burmese words as a result.

2. System

I told my developer friend that I would like to do it and we started a group of three to create this system. We started this system on 16th September, 2020. We decided our first consonants at our first meeting on 28th September, 2020.

consonants									
က	ka	ခ	kha	ဂ	ga	ဃ	gá	င	nga
စ	ca	ဆ	sa	ဇ	za	ဈ	zá	ည	nya
တ	tá	ဌ	htá	ဍ	da	ဎ	da	ဏ	ná
တ	ta	ထ	hta	ဒ	da	ဓ	dá	န	na
ပ	pa	ဖ	pha	ဗ	bá	ဘ	ba	မ	ma
ယ	ya	ရ	ra	လ	la	ဝ	wa	သ	tha
		ဟ	ha	င	lá	အ	a		

The above table is the finalized result of our meeting. They are based on Myanglish that most young adults are using in Myanmar currently, to avoid using Burmese keyboard. However, since Myanmar obviously has more vowels and consonants, we decided to use circumflex for stop sounds such as “ga” for “ဂ” and “gá” for “ဃ”. Moreover, there is “အ” both in consonant and vowel. Those two are differentiated by using “a” for consonant “အ” and “ah” for vowel “အ”.

As for the combinations, we decided every one of them with care. There are sounds that we are typing in the same way. It works well as we are just using them in sentences but if we were to type in English and generate Burmese words, there can be ambiguous cases. Therefore, first of all, acute symbol is used for same-sounded alphabets such as “kí” for “ကို” and “ki” for “ကို”, and two dots on alphabet for those combining with “ြ” such as “kyä” for “ကြ” and “kya” for “ကျ”. Moreover, for long sounds such as “ကောင်း”, doubling the last word is a great solution.

The following table is the complete example of the first alphabet in Burmese language “က” and its combinations.

vowels							
က	ka	ကာ	kar				
ကီ	ki						
ကူ	ku	ကူ	ku				
ကေ	kay	ကဲ	kel				
ကော	kaw	ကော်	kaww	ကို	ko		
				ကံ	kan	ကား	karr
အသံစဉ်							
က	ka	ကာ	kar	ကား	karr		
ကီ	ki	ကီ	ki	ကီး	kii		
ကူ	ku	ကူ	ku	ကူး	kuu		
ကေ	kay	ကေ	kae	ကေး	kayy		
ကဲ	kel	ကဲ	kelt				
ကော	kaw	ကော	kawt				
ကံ	kan	ကံ	kant				
ကို	ko	ကို	kot	ကိုး	koo		
ကက်	kak	ကောက်	kauk	ကိုက်	kake		
ကင်	kin	ကင်	kint	ကင်း	kinn		
ကောင်	kaung	ကောင့်	kaunt	ကောင်း	kaungg		
ကိုင်	kine	ကိုင်	kinet	ကိုင်း	kinee		
ကစ်	kit						
ကတ်	kat	ကတ်	kate	ကုတ်	küte		
ကန်	ken	ကန်	kent	ကန်း	kenn		
ကိန်	kin	ကိန်	kint	ကိန်း	kinn		
ကုန်	kün	ကုန်	künt	ကုန်း	künn		
ကပ်	kap	ကပ်	kipe	ကုပ်	küpe		
ကမ်	kam	ကမ်	kamt	ကမ်း	kamm		
ကိမ်	kim	ကိမ်	kimt	ကိမ်း	kimm		
ကုမ်	küme	ကုမ်	kümet	ကုမ်း	kümee		
ကုံ	kone	ကုံ	konet	ကုံး	konee		
ကယ်	kai						
မျဉ်းစဉ်							
ကျ	kya	ကျ	kyä	ကွ	kwa	ကွ (မှ)	hma
ကျွ	kywa	ကျွ	kywä	ကျွ		ကျွ ()	
ကွ (လွ)	hiwa	ကျွ (မျ)	hmya	ကျွ			

As shown in the above table, there are definitely exceptions for some words as our Myanglish is based on the one that many people are widely using now. “-aunt” (“-ာဉ်”) is the first combination that deviates from our rules because if we write “-ာဉ်” according to the rules, it will be so much different from the one we are using currently. Since it is a word that is used frequently, we decided to leave it as it is. Second word is “န” which was decided to use “ñ”. This shows how much we do not understand phonetics and linguistics in a way that we only thought of turning our daily-using words into some kind of standard. That was because we aimed

to create a keyboard that can be used widely by many people without the need to learn a whole new system.

Additionally, there are rules that we decided for keyboard use while setting the standard for alphabets. In order to avoid ambiguous words, no capital letter can be used. There are some doubled words in Burmese language and those words must be written separately in order to generate the decent Burmese word, e.g. ကမ္ဘာ > ကမ်ဘာ၊ ပြဿနာ > ပြဿနာ။ The letters “á”, “î”, “û” and “ñ” must be typed using the shift key on the keyboard. For instance, if we want to type “á”, we must use shift+“a”. The following are a list of exceptions that are similar in pronunciation but different in spelling:

1. “လည်းကောင်း” as “leekaungg” while “၎င်း” as “l'kaungg”
2. “နှိုက်” as “hnaike” while “နှို” as “hnike”
3. “ရွှေ” as “rwae” while “ရှ်” as “rwaê”
4. “အိ” as “aî” while “လှ” as “î” and “၏” as “eî”

There is one thing that we must be aware of. We cannot just create words randomly. There has to be a systematic standard to combine with any alphabets. Exceptions cannot be avoided but the less of those, the better the system.

3. Conclusion

It is the system that we created without taking phonetics into account since all of us do not have expertise in that field. Since both of them have their own job and are only helping me with my idea, they now withdraw from this project as I am co-operating with SRMA. They also gave me full permission to use this system as my own. There are still missing things and mistakes in this system. Anyone is welcome to modify or correct this system.